

UNACCEPTABLE CHANGE J&K Apni Party supporters at a silent protest against the delimitation commission's draft recommendations in Srinagar, Dec. 29, 2021

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KASHMIR DELIMITATION

Setting Boundaries

By Moazum Mohammad in Srinagar

For centuries, the mighty Pir Panjal range has stood as a barrier, sometimes isolating the Kashmir valley from Jammu for months together. Though the construction in recent years has reduced the separation, this geography is part of why the region is seen as two distinct areas—Jammu and Kashmir. In that regard, some proposals in the ongoing delimitation process, including one that ties two districts in Jammu—Poonch and Rajouri—to Kashmir's Anantnag, has many questioning the rationale being applied.

On February 4, the delimitation commission—led by retired Supreme Court judge Ranjana Prakash Desai—released its second draft delimitation. Among other changes, it proposed six new seats for Jammu (Kathua, Reasi, Doda, Rajouri, Kishtwar and Samba) and one for Kashmir (Kupwara), taking their tallies in the assembly to 43 and 47, respectively. The delimitation also departs from convention by considering geography and topography as well as population in drawing boundaries, rather than just population. In the new map, 28 constituencies have had their borders redrawn and 19 have been renamed.

The proposed changes have sparked resentment in both Jammu and Kashmir. For instance, the proposal that Jammu's Suchetgarh be dissolved and merged into R.S. Pura has triggered a wave of anger, with over 100 BJP workers resigning in protest. In Kashmir, where 10 constituencies have been renamed, the National Conference (NC) has described the renaming as an attempt "to obliterate history". NC leader Shamima Firdous, a two-term MLA from Srinagar's Habba Kadal—which has been dissolved—points out that names are symbols of culture and history. Habba Kadal had been named after the poetess and queen of Kashmir Habba Khatoon. The removal of such names, says Firdous, is "an assault on our history and past".

Another contentious proposal is to merge Jammu's Rajouri and Poonch into Kashmir's Anantnag to form a new Lok Sabha constituency, Anantnag-Rajouri. The population is mostly Muslim in Rajouri (62 per cent) and almost entirely so in Poonch (90.4 per cent). Nadeem Khan, a member of the Pahari community in Poonch, says he cannot understand the logic of combining Poonch into Anantnag given the distance. He points out that it is over 300 km from one to the other via Jammu, and that the Mughal Road connecting them through Shopian remains closed for five or six months of the year. "With this in mind, we want to know the methodology [the